

Vive l'empéreur
This late 19th-century painting of the charge of the 4th Hussars at the Battle of Friedland, 1807 *(above)* gives a somewhat idealized picture of the bravery and patriotism of Napoleon's troops. Hussars and other light cavalrymen cut even more dashing figures in their full dress uniforms. A chasseur on parade wore a splendid plume on his shako *(right)* instead of the pompom he wore on the battlefield.

As a general under the French republic, and later as Emperor of France, Napoleon Bonaparte based his style of warfare on rapid movement of forces to bring the enemy to battle, and aggressive battlefield tactics to crush his adversary in the field. In his increasingly large armies, infantry, artillery, and cavalry all had their parts to play. Key functions of the cavalry included the mounting of decisive charges at crucial points in the battle and the pursuit of a routed enemy to complete an overwhelming victory.

The French Revolution of 1789 had a profound effect on the French army and other areas of French society. The cavalry had always been the most aristocratic element of France's armed forces. Many of its officers were hostile to the revolution and emigrated; others who would willingly have continued to serve their country were dismissed because the radical revolutionary government disapproved of their social origins. This was the fate of the Marquis de Grouchy, who was stripped of his rank in 1793, but he later rose to become one of Napoleon's most distinguished cavalry commanders. For some men of humble origin, however, the revolution provided unprecedented opportunity – Joachim Murat, son of a village postmaster, enlisted as a cavalry trooper in 1787 and was a colonel by 1795, while Michel Ney, the son of a barrel-maker, joined the hussars also in 1787 and was a general commanding a brigade by 1796.

RIDERS AND MOUNTS

But overall, despite the promotion of some talented individuals, the revolution played havoc with the French cavalry and it performed poorly in most of the battles of the Revolutionary Wars (1792–1801). Napoleon inherited a force short of horses, training, and confidence. As consul and then emperor, he set about reforming and upgrading the cavalry arm as a vital element in his rebuilding of the entire French army.

Of the two key components of an effective cavalry force – riders and horses – Napoleon found the human element easier to deal with. From 1799, when Napoleon took over the government as First Consul, annual conscription filled the army's ranks, bringing a constant flow of fresh recruits to serve alongside veterans of the army of the monarchy and of the revolutionary *levée en masse* (mass conscription) of 1793. Cavalry regiments were all given magnificent new uniforms, with an emphasis on colour and flamboyance, as part of a successful campaign to raise morale. Napoleon's regime inspired patriotic zeal, revolutionary enthusiasm, and the attachment of men who owed to it their advancement in life.

The shortage of horses was a problem that was much harder to remedy because it required years to breed sufficient numbers of the right mounts. When Napoleon's Grande Armée first assembled in 1805, dragoons were ordered to fight on foot because of lack of horses. It was the victories at Austerlitz in 1805 and at Jena and Auerstadt in 1806 that effectively solved the problem by allowing the French to take large numbers of horses from the defeated Austrians and Prussians.

GLAMOUR AND HARDSHIP

The cavalry service, with its dashing uniforms and its "death or glory" fighting tradition, naturally attracted adventurous young men with a taste for glamour and style. Napoleonic cavalrymen were famed for their hard drinking, their short tempers that easily flared into fights, and above all their relentless womanizing. But life in the cavalry was on the whole far from luxurious, even when not on campaign.



FULL DRESS SHAKO OF THE FIRST REGIMENT OF CHASSEURS